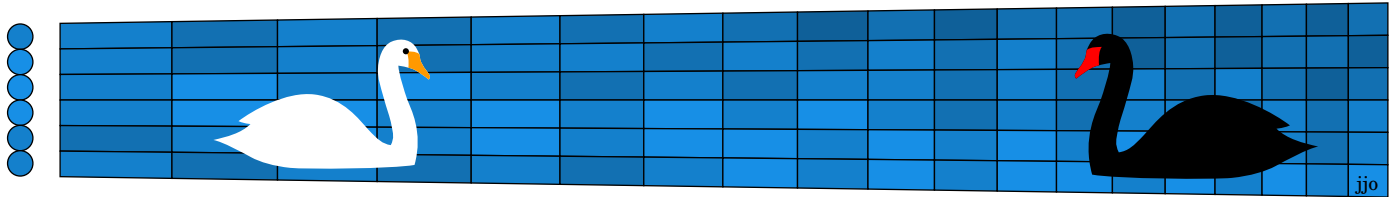


September Fretboard Exercises

Sightread the Swans in September



Glide smoothly in major and minor . . .

Exercise 1: I 1 II 2 III 4 IV 4 V 3

♩ = 90

Exercise 2: I 2

♩ = 120

Exercise 1	Saint-Saëns(1886): Carnival of the Animals, No.13 The Swan . . .	1
Exercise 2	Sibelius(1896): The Swan of Tuonela, Op.22 No.2	1

Real Swans are interesting on their own, independent of all the cultural lore that surrounds them. Despite the European references to black swans, all swans in the Northern Hemisphere have white plumage; black plumage is found in the Southern Hemisphere and the completely black swan is limited to Australia.

- <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Swan>

The Swan Song emitted when dying is part of that cultural lore beginning with the ancient Greeks and has been largely overstated. Some swan species do have an additional tracheal loop in their sternum which can produce a long drawn out series of notes as the lungs collapse while dying. But it's not the beautiful final song after a silent life.

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Swan_song#Ornithological_accuracy

“The Swan” by Camille Saint-Saëns (Exercise 1) is one of thirteen “animals” in his humorous “Carnival of the Animals”. It is the only movement that he allowed to be published while he was alive, the others being too frivolous for a serious composer (for example, one of the other animals was a Pianist, playing scale exercises). The Swan has been a favorite of cellists (hear Yo-Yo Ma below) but has also found a home on the **theremin** (hear the expert Clara Rockmore below).

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Carnival_of_the_Animals
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Le_cygne
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JO5QYvxcvi4> Yo-Yo Ma (2016)
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pSzTPGlna5U> Clara Rockmore (1981)

“The Swan of Tuonela” is part of old Finnish pagan beliefs about the afterlife in a place called *Tuonela*. The dead, both good and bad, had to cross a deep dark river guarded by a black swan that sings death spells. Jean Sibelius composed a suite of tone poems based on such legends from the Finnish epic *Kalevala*. His “Swan of Tuonela”, second in the suite, was composed for *cor anglais*, a kind of oboe with an angled neck and bulbous bell that plays a fifth lower. Americans know it as the English horn, but “anglais” derives from either “angelic” or “angled”, not “anglican”. Here, as Exercise 2, it has been shortened significantly, even from the version now in Chromatic Fretboard Exercises; the original piece spans over 9 minutes. The ethereal sound of the original has been cited by name in an alleged after death communication as most like what one hears in the afterlife.

- <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tuonela>
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Swan_of_Tuonela
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cor_anglais
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=w5xJAOIXdUI> The Metropolitan Orchestra (2018)
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QQzBh4mGeRo&t=3s> The Afterlife of Billy Fingers

These exercises are from the yet to be released book “Chromatic Fretboard Exercises”, which contains over a thousand such exercises and will be made available for free on IMSLP. The contents may be freely copied and modified, but with the condition that they be attributed to J. J. Olson (CC-BY license).

Interested? Contact Jeff Olson at jjocanoe@gmail.com

*P.S. It easiest to follow these links if you **get the pdf** as indicated on the first page.*